

Git .gitignore - Detailed Guide

What is .gitignore?

.gitignore tells Git which files and folders should not be tracked in a repository.

Why Use .gitignore?

Prevent committing dependencies, build outputs, logs, IDE settings, temporary files, and secrets.

Basic Syntax

Ignore a file: test.txt

Ignore a folder: logs/

Ignore extension: *.log

Wildcards

* matches multiple characters. ? matches a single character. ** matches recursively across directories.

Environment Files

Common patterns: .env, .env.local, .env.*. These often contain secrets and should not be committed.

Build Folders

React/Vite: dist/

Next.js: .next/

Java/Spring Boot: target/

Negation Rules

Use ! to re-include a file. Example: *.log then !important.log

Important Limitation

.gitignore does not affect files already tracked by Git.

Stop Tracking Existing Files

git rm --cached filename

git rm -r --cached foldername

Debugging

```
git check-ignore -v filename  
git status --ignored
```

Global Git Ignore

```
git config --global core.excludesfile ~/.gitignore_global
```

Sample React/Vite .gitignore

```
node_modules/  
dist/  
*.log  
.env  
.env.*  
.vscode/  
.idea/  
.DS_Store  
Thumbs.db
```

Interview Questions

What is .gitignore? Does it affect tracked files? What does ! mean? Difference between * and **?